

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1053

By Sparks

A RESOLUTION to honor those individuals and organizations that are working to address adolescent mental health, bullying, and the harmful effects of social media on Tennessee's young people.

WHEREAS, Tennessee faces an urgent mental health crisis, with rising rates of anxiety, depression, self-harm, and suicide, particularly among adolescent girls; and

WHEREAS, behind every statistic is a real story of pain, including the tragic loss of Rivers "Riv" Kelleher on September 12, 2025, just days before her fifteenth birthday, which inspired her family and community to establish the "We Live for Riv" ministry and movement to support youth facing depression, anxiety, bullying, and other challenges; and

WHEREAS, alongside other mental health advocates, many of whom are members of this General Assembly, the "We Live for Riv" movement has raised local and national awareness of youth suicide, bullying, social isolation, and the harmful impacts of social media; and

WHEREAS, research, including information found in Jonathan Haidt's *The Anxious Generation*, shows dramatic increases in adolescent mental health issues since the early 2010s, linked to widespread smartphone and social media use, engagement-driven algorithms, cyberbullying, body image pressures, reduced face-to-face interaction, and diminished unstructured play; and

WHEREAS, adolescent girls are disproportionately affected, and factors such as loneliness, overprotective environments, and excessive screen time contribute to unprecedented psychological distress that cannot be dismissed as mere "growing pains"; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee has emerged as a leader in addressing Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs) and promoting Positive Childhood Experiences (PCEs)—such as stable

relationships, supportive schools, and community connections—as protective factors that build resilience and mitigate risks; and

WHEREAS, working in the area of suicide prevention are the Jason Foundation, the American Foundation for Suicide Prevention, and the Tennessee Suicide Prevention Network (TSPN), which in coordination with the Tennessee Department of Mental Health and Substance Abuse Services (TDMHSAS), advances evidence-informed prevention and coordination, while the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline provides free, confidential, 24/7 support as a key part of the State's behavioral health continuum; and

WHEREAS, additional therapies include cognitive behavior therapy, dialectical behavior therapy, trauma-focused therapies, acceptance and commitment therapy, group therapy, mindfulness meditation, yoga, exercise, team sports, music therapy, art therapy, dance/movement therapy, writing/expressive journaling, volunteering/service, community engagement, sleep hygiene practices, digital wellness practices, time in nature, gardening/horticultural therapy, animal-assisted therapy, gratitude practices, and clinical treatment paired with protective practices; and

WHEREAS, the "We Live for Riv" community exemplifies turning pain into purpose through advocacy, awareness, empathy, and action, reminding us that mental health is central to our State's future and requires compassion over complacency; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor those individuals and organizations, including the memory of Rivers "Riv" Kelleher and the We Live for Riv movement, the Jason Foundation, the American Foundation for Suicide Prevention, and the Tennessee Suicide Prevention Network, that are working to address adolescent mental health, bullying, and the harmful effects of social media on Tennessee's young people.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that enrolled copies of this resolution be prepared and transmitted to the We Live for Riv organization, the family of Rivers "Riv" Kelleher, the Jason Foundation, the American Foundation for Suicide Prevention, the Tennessee Suicide Prevention Network, the Tennessee Department of Mental Health and Substance Abuse Services, and the Tennessee Department of Education.